

Political Theory

Chapter 2 : Freedom

Welcome to AnithUncommon's Sample Resources!

This sample will be divided into **three** parts: Introduction to Samples (this part), Lesson Objectives (What is Expected From Students), and most crucially, Syllabus Contents.

Note that the 'Syllabus Content' does NOT stand as a complete syllabus itself; rather, it is a tight compilation of notes gathered by (Mentor Name) to create a comprehensive sample for students.

If you want a complete version of these notes and think that you need help in Political Theory, join our nonprofit!

Gmail: [anithuncommon](#)

Instagram handle: [@anithuncommon](#)

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— Made by students, for students

Lesson Objectives:

At the end of the lesson, students should be *able* to...

- **Understand** the importance of freedom for individuals and societies.
- **Explain** the difference between the negative and positive dimensions of freedom.
- **Explain** what is meant by the term 'harm principle'.

Reflective Questions to Consider:

Human history provides many examples of people and communities which have been dominated, or enslaved, or exploited, by more powerful groups. But it also provides us with inspiring examples of heroic struggles against such domination. However, given the diverse interests and ambitions of people any form of social living requires some rules and regulation.

Below is the following core questions you will face as we explore this chapter:

- What exactly is 'freedom' which people have been constantly willing to sacrifice and die for?
- How can we work to evolve principles by which we can distinguish between socially necessary constraints and other restrictions on freedom without hampering it in general?

Syllabus Outline:

Unit 2: Freedom

Tips!

- The literal idea and concept of freedom may feel extremely abstract to students. To tackle this, try relating every single topic you study to a real-life example or situation from YOUR specific community.
- Try not to be biased ONLY towards freedom and critically think how freedom could actually even be negative, and what we could do to ensure freedom as well as security while learning about this lesson.

Activities in Class:

- Lesson Breakdown
- After the lesson, discuss with your mentor the possible 'cons' of freedom. Then, imagine that you are the President/Prime Minister of your country. Discuss with your mentor what you'd do to promote freedom in your country WHILE ensuring the security of your people. Make sure to think about various aspects such as digital rights (freedom of expression vs security), rights of citizens during war, freedom of speech, freedom to make trades and so on!

Freedom

Section 2.1 : The Ideal of Freedom - Case Studies !

- The autobiography of one of the greatest persons of the twentieth century, Nelson Mandela, is titled **Long Walk to Freedom**. In this book he talks about his **personal struggle against the apartheid regime in South Africa**, about the **resistance of his people to the segregationist policies of the white regime**, about the **humiliations**,

Mentor's Notes

Imagine what it meant to give up one's youth for an ideal, to voluntarily give up the pleasure of talking with one's friends, of

hardships and police brutalities suffered by the **black people** of South Africa. These ranged from being bundled into townships and being denied easy movement about the country, to being denied a free choice of whom to marry.

- Collectively, **such measures constituted a body of constraints** imposed by the apartheid regime that **discriminated between citizens based on their race**. For Mandela and his colleagues it was the struggle against such unjust constraints, the **struggle to remove the obstacles to the freedom of all the people of South Africa** (not just the black or the coloured but also the white people), that was the Long Walk to Freedom.
- For this freedom, Mandela spent **twenty-seven years of his life in jail**, often in **solitary confinement**. For freedom Mandela paid these many years of his life, losing all his youth for not only his freedom but also that of his 'brothers and sisters' as he called them in 'A Long Walk to Freedom'.
- Now, take another case. **Gandhiji's** thoughts on **non-violence** have been a **source of inspiration** for Aung San Suu Kyi as she remained **under house arrest in Myanmar, separated from her children, unable to visit her husband when he was dying of cancer**, because she **feared that if she left Myanmar to visit him in England she would not be able to return**.
- Aung San Suu Kyi saw her **freedom as connected to the freedom of her people**. Her **book of essays** bears the title '**Freedom from Fear**'. She says, "for me real freedom is freedom from fear and unless you can live free from fear you cannot live a dignified human life". These are deep thoughts that lead us to pause and consider their implications.
- We must **not**, her words suggest, **be afraid of the opinions of other people**, or of the **attitude of authority**, or of **the reactions of the members of our community to**

playing one's favourite game (Mandela loved boxing), of wearing one's favourite clothes, of listening to one's favourite music, of enjoying the many festivals that are part of one's life. Imagine giving all these up and choosing instead to be locked up alone in a room, not knowing when one would be released, only because one campaigned for the freedom of one's people. Now envision why YOU think someone would do so much for what is called 'freedom'? What would you do?

the things we want to do, of the **ridicule of our peers**, or of **speaking our mind**. Yet we find that we **often exhibit such fear**. For Aung San Suu Kyi, living a '**dignified human life**' requires us to be able to **overcome such fear**.

- From these two case studies of Nelson Mandela and Aung San Suu Kyi, we can see **the power of the ideal of freedom**, an ideal that was at the centre of the struggles of the peoples of Asia and Africa against British, French and Portuguese colonialism.

Section 2.2 : What is Freedom and The Sources of Constraints

- A simple answer to the question 'what is freedom' is **absence of constraints**. Freedom is said to **exist when external constraints on the individual are absent**. In terms of this definition **an individual could be considered free if he/she is not subject to external controls or coercion** and is **able to make independent decisions** and **act in an autonomous way**. However, **absence of constraints** is only **one dimension** of freedom.
- Freedom is also about **expanding the ability of people to freely express themselves and develop their potential**. Freedom in this sense is **the condition in which people can develop their creativity and capabilities**. Both these **aspects of freedom** — the **absence of external constraints** as well as **the existence of conditions in which people can develop their talents** — are **important**. A **free society** would be one which **enables all its members to develop their potential** with the **minimum of social constraints**.
- **No individual living in society can hope to enjoy total absence** of any kind of **constraints or restrictions**. It becomes **necessary** then to determine **which social**

Can you now think of someone from your community/country who has struggled for their own freedom or the freedom of others? Try analysing their perspective on freedom and dignity like these case studies!

Freedom, in this sense, allows the full development of the

constraints are justified and which are not. To understand which social constraints are necessary, discussions on freedom need to look at the core relationship between the individual and the society (or group, community, or state) within which they are placed. That is, we need to examine the relationship between individuals and society. • We would need to see which features of the society allow the individual the freedom to choose, decide or act, and which do not. Further we need to see if the principles which we use to differentiate necessary from unnecessary constraints also apply to the relationships between individuals and groups and nations. • To be free means to reduce or minimise social constraints that limit our ability to make choices freely. However, this is only one aspect of freedom. To put it in another way, freedom also has a positive dimension. To be free a society must widen the area in which individuals, groups, communities or nations, will be able to charter their own destiny and be what they wish to be. Freedom is considered valuable because it allows us to make choices and to exercise our judgement. It permits the exercise of the individual's powers of reason and judgement. • Restrictions on the freedom of individuals may come from domination and external controls. Such restrictions may be imposed by force or they may be imposed by a government through laws which embody the power of the rulers over the people and which may have the backing of force. This was the form of constraint represented by colonial rulers over their subjects, or by the system of apartheid in South Africa. • Some form of government may be inevitable but if the government is a democratic one, the members of a state could retain some control over their rulers. That is why democratic government is considered to be an	individual's creativity, sensibilities and capabilities: be it in sports, science, art, music or exploration. A free society is one that enables one to pursue one's interests with a minimum of constraints. We see people around us ready to fight for all kinds of reasons ranging from the serious to the trivial. Rage while driving on the roads, fighting over parking spaces, quarrels over housing or land, disagreements regarding whether a particular film should be screened, all these, and many other issues,
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important means of protecting the freedom of people. But **constraints on freedom** can also result from **social inequality**.

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Section 2.3 : Why do we need constraints?

- We cannot live in a world where there are no constraints. We need some constraints or else society would descend into chaos. Differences may exist between people regarding their ideas and opinions, they may have conflicting ambitions, they may compete to control scarce resources. There are numerous reasons why disagreements may develop in a society which may express themselves through open conflict.
- Therefore **every society needs some mechanisms to control violence and settle disputes**. So long as we are able to **respect each other's views** and **do not** attempt to **impose our views on others** we may be able to live **freely** and with **minimum constraints**. Ideally, **in a free society** we should be able to **hold our views**, develop our own **rules of living**, and **pursue our choices**.
- But the creation of such a society too requires some constraints. At the very least, it requires that we be willing to respect differences of views, opinions and beliefs. However, sometimes, we think that a strong commitment to our beliefs requires that we must oppose all those who differ from or reject our views. We see their views or ways of living as unacceptable or even undesirable. Under such circumstances we need some legal and political restraints to ensure that differences may be discussed and debated without one group coercively imposing its views on the other. Worse still, we may be confronted with attempts to bully or harass us so that we conform to their wishes. If so, we may want stronger support from law to ensure that our freedom is protected.

can lead to conflict and violence, perhaps even loss of life. Can you now think why constraints are necessary for maintaining social order? Try thinking of the kind of constraints you would introduce for the given situations.

Section 2.4 : Harm Principle

- To answer the questions given on the right-hand side we have to address the issue of the **limits, competence, and consequences of the imposition**. We also have to engage with another issue that **John Stuart Mill** stated so eloquently in his **essay 'On Liberty'**. In the discussions in political theory it is called the 'harm principle'. Let us quote his statement and then try to explain it.
- *...the sole end for which mankind are warranted, individually or collectively, in interfering with the liberty of action of any of their number, is self-protection. That the only purpose for which power can be rightfully exercised over any member of a civilised community, against his will, is to prevent harm to others.*
- Mill introduces here an **important distinction**. He **distinguishes between 'self-regarding' actions**, i.e., those **actions that have consequences** only for the **individual actor** and **nobody else**, and the **'other regarding' actions**, i.e., those **actions that also have consequences for others**. He argues that **with respect to actions or choices that affect only one's self, self-regarding actions**, the **state** (or any other external authority) has **no business to interfere**.
- However, as **freedom is at the core of human society**, and is **so crucial for a dignified human life**, it should **only be constrained in special circumstances**. The **'harm caused' must be 'serious'**. For **minor harm**, Mill recommends only **social disapproval** and **not the force of law**.
- The example given on the right-hand side about playing loud music is **minor harm** and should **only provoke social disapproval**. It is **not a fit case for legal punishment**. **Constraining actions by the force of law** should only happen when the **other regarding actions** cause **serious harm to definite individuals**. Otherwise **society** must

The important question however is to identify which constraints on freedom are necessary and justifiable and which are not? What sort of authority, external to the individual, may justifiably say what can be done and what cannot? Further, are there any areas of our life and action that should be left free of all external constraints?

bear the inconvenience in the spirit of protecting freedom.

- People should be ready to tolerate different ways of life, different points of view, and different interests, so long as they do not cause harm to others. But such **tolerance need not be extended to views and actions** which may **put people in danger or foment hatred against them**. Hate campaigns cause serious harm to the freedom of others and **actions that cause 'serious harm'** are actions on which **constraints can be imposed**.
- But we must make sure that **the constraints imposed are not so severe** that they **destroy freedom itself**. For example, we must not ask for life imprisonment for those who only conduct hate campaigns. Maybe some restriction on their movement, or some curtailment of their right to hold public meetings can be considered especially if they continue to carry on this campaign in spite of warnings by the state to desist from conducting such campaigns.

Section 2.5 : Negative and Positive Liberty and Freedom of Expression

- All we need to recognise is that the **negative liberty tradition** argues for an **inviolable area of non-interference** in which the **individual can express himself or herself**. If the **area is too small** then **human dignity gets compromised**. It is **concerned with explaining the idea of 'freedom from'**.
- In contrast, the arguments of **positive liberty** are concerned with explaining the idea of **'freedom to'**. They **are in response to the answer 'who governs me?'** to which the **ideal answer is 'I govern myself'**. Positive liberty discussions have a long tradition that can be traced to **Rousseau, Hegel, Marx, Gandhi, Aurobindo**, and also to those who draw their inspiration from these thinkers. It is concerned with **looking at the conditions**

Or put in simple language it would be: 'That's my business, I'll do what I like', or 'How does it concern you, if it does not affect you?' In contrast, with respect to actions that have consequences for others, actions which may cause harm to them, there is some case for external interference. After all, if your actions cause me harm then surely I must be saved from such harm by some external authority? In this case it is the state which can constrain a person from acting in a way that causes harm to someone else.

For example the playing of loud music in an apartment building should bring only social disapproval from the other residents of the

and nature of the relationship between the individual and society and of improving these conditions such that there are fewer constraints to the development of the individual's personality. The individual to develop his or her capability must get the benefit of enabling positive conditions in material, political and social domains.

That is, the person must not be constrained by poverty or unemployment; they must have adequate material resources to pursue their wants and needs. They must also have the opportunity to participate in the decision making process so that the laws made reflect their choices, or at least take those preferences into account. Above all, to develop their mind and intellect, individuals must have access to education and other associated opportunities necessary to lead a reasonably good life.

- **Positive liberty** recognises that one can be free only in society (not outside it) and hence tries to make that society such that it enables the development of the individual whereas **negative liberty** is only concerned with the inviolable area of non-interference and not with the conditions in society, outside this area, as such. Of course negative liberty would like to expand this minimum area as much as is possible keeping in mind, however, the stability of society. **Generally they both go together and support each other**, but it can happen that tyrants justify their rule by invoking arguments of positive liberty.
- One of the issues that is considered to belong to the minimum area of 'non-interference' is the freedom of expression. J.S.Mill set out good reasons why freedom of expression should not be restricted. This is a good case for discussion. **Freedom of expression** is a fundamental value and for that society must be willing to bear some inconvenience to protect it from people who want to restrict it. Voltaire once quoted — 'I disapprove of what you say but I will defend to death your right to say it'.

building. They should not involve the police. They should indicate their disapproval of the inconvenience that playing loud music has caused them, by perhaps refusing to greet the person who plays the music disregarding the harm it is causing others. The harm that playing loud music causes is that of preventing those in other apartments from talking, or sleeping, or listening to their own music.

We may here ask the obvious question: Is the choice of what clothes to wear in different situations – school, playing-field,

- After reading the case study on the right-hand side, banning is an easy solution for the short term since it meets the immediate demand but is very harmful for the long-term prospects of freedom in a society because once one begins to ban then one develops a habit of banning. But does this mean that we should never ban? After all, we do have censorship of films. Is it not similar to banning, where only a portion of a film is banned and not the whole film?
- The question that is often debated, therefore, is: When should one ban and when should one not? Should one never ban? Just for interest, in England anyone who is employed to work for the Royal household is constrained by contract (a constraint?) from writing about the inner affairs of the household. So if such a person were to leave employment they would be unable to give an interview or write an article or author a book about the politics of the Royal household. Is this an unjustifiable constraint on the freedom of expression?
- Constraints of different kinds thus exist and we are subject to them in different situations. While reflecting on such situations we need to realise that when **constraints are backed by organised social — religious or cultural — authority or by the might of the state**, they **restrict our freedom** in ways that are **difficult to fight against**. However, if we willingly, or for the sake of pursuing our goals or ambitions, accept certain restrictions, our freedom is not similarly limited. In any case if we are not coerced into accepting the conditions, then we cannot claim that our freedom has been curtailed.

Summary

We began by saying that freedom is the **absence of external constraints**. We have now come to realise that **freedom**

office – a choice that belongs to the minimum area and therefore one that cannot be interfered with by external authority or is it a choice that can be interfered with by state, religious authority. Negative liberty arguments are in response to the question: ‘Over what area am I the master?’

At various times there have been demands to ban books, plays, films, or academic articles in research

embodies our capacity and our ability to make choices. And when we make choices, we have also to accept responsibility for our actions and their consequences. Our capacity to make the right choices, to assess in a reasoned manner available options, and shoulder the responsibility of our actions, have to be built through education and cultivation of judgement just as much as it needs to be nurtured by limiting the authority of the state and the society.

journals. Let us think about this demand to ban books in the light of our discussion so far which sees freedom as 'the making of choices', where a distinction is made between 'negative and positive liberty', where we recognise the need for 'justifiable constraints' but these have to be supported by proper procedures and important moral arguments.

Some years ago Deepa Mehta, film maker, wanted to make a film about widows in Varanasi. It sought to explore the plight of widows but there was a strong protest from a section of the polity who felt that it would show India in a very bad light, who felt it was being made to cater to foreign audiences, who felt it would bring a bad

	name to the ancient town. They refused to allow it to be made and as a result it could not be made in Varanasi. It was subsequently made elsewhere. Similarly the book Ramayana Retold by Aubrey Menon and The Satanic Verses by Salman Rushdie were banned after protest from some sections of society. The film The Last Temptation of Christ and the play Me Nathuram Boltey were also banned after protests.
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Mentors' Sources:

<https://ncert.nic.in/textbook.php?keps1=2-8>

<https://www.scribd.com/document/727887695/Freedom-ch-2-Notes-and-question-answers-with-you>

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<https://archive.org/details/freedomfromfearo00aungrich>